the perfect hour in which to begin Akbar's lessons – but, like many children on their first day of school wish they could, Akbar 'disappeared' when the appointed moment arrived; 'no trace of him could be found'.[54]

If Mulla Isamuddin hoped that Akbar would grow fonder of his company over time, he was wrong. In fact, the teacher was soon dismissed. According to Abul Fazl, Isamuddin's fault was his all-absorbing devotion to pigeons. Perhaps the tutor was an avid pigeon-flyer; it was a popular sport. Babur's father died, famously, falling from his dovecote. The historical evidence, however, suggests that the poor mullah was only trying to keep pace with his young student. As shy as Akbar was of study, so he was besotted by animals.

Abul Fazl puts it in most lofty terms. If the prince was fascinated by the camel's 'strange make and ways', delighted in leading one about by the reins, or feeding brambles to another, laughing with joy and alarm, perhaps, when the large animal plucked its food from his small hand, this was a form of serious reflection 'under the guise of amusement'. Similarly with Akbar's 'thoughts to the delight in an Arab horse', and the spread of 'the wings of his genius' through pigeon-flying – for all that Abul Fazl will try to mould his subject into the shape of a little philosopher, Akbar's mind in 'the guise of sport perform[ing] the work of adoration' even when he was playing with his dogs ('inwardly it was quickening the senses') you cannot but imagine a boy tearing through the grounds of Kabul fort, delighting in the flap of pigeons, the panting of hounds, the thunder of horses.

Isamuddin could not lure Akbar to the classroom, nor could his successor, Maulana Bayazid. Eventually, Humayun had to draw lots to find a tutor for his son; the job fell to Mulla Abdul Qadir,, who found no more success in his thankless job than had his predecessors.

Akbar's attendants, less inclined to regard their charge with the worshipful gaze of his future historian, complained to Humayun about the boy. Akbar was about nine years old at this time, and had just returned to Kabul after Kamran's raid and Hindal's death. Humayun was still away on Kamran's trail. When complaints about Akbar reached him, Humayun sent his son a letter. Abul Fazl finds the idea preposterous. 'For what need has he who has been taught at the Divine school – of human instructions?'[55] As if to make up for Humayun's faux pas, Abul Fazl cites another miracle. A man sent to